

Saw an AI defender make a claim that the water usage of data centers is an overblown myth, is this true?

Posted by u/Emergency_War_2714 • • 0 points • 201 comments

[<https://andymasley.substack.com/p/the-ai-water-issue-is-fake>]
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From the linked article:

“The idea that AI’s water usage is a serious national emergency caught on for three reasons:

- * People get upset at the idea of a physical resource like water being spent on a digital product, especially one they don’t see value in, and don’t factor in just how often this happens everywhere.
- * People haven’t internalized how many other people are using AI. AI’s water use looks ridiculous if you think of it as a small marginal new thing. It looks tiny when you divide it by the hundreds of millions of people using AI every day.
- * People are easily alarmed by contextless large numbers, like the number of gallons of water a data center is using. They compare these large numbers to other regular things they do, not to other normal industries and processes in society. They aren’t aware of how much water society uses on other normal industries.

Together, these create the impression that AI water use is a problem. It is not. Regardless of whether you love or hate AI, it is not possible to actually look at the numbers involved without coming to the conclusion that this is a fake problem. This problem’s hyped up for clicks by a lot of scary articles that completely fall apart when you look at the simple easy-to-access facts on the ground. These articles have contributed to establishing fake “common wisdom” among everyday people that AI uses a lot of water.”

Thoughts and counter arguments?

Comments

u/joehendrey-temp • 1 points • 2026-02-19 04:13 UTC

Any time anyone is making claims about water usage for anything I'm always deeply sceptical. There's practically nothing we do that uses water up, and we have an effectively infinite supply anyway. Yes, diverting fresh water will have an impact on the surrounding ecosystem, but if the people making the claims are focusing on how much is being used rather than specifically where it's being diverted from they're almost certainly lying about the impact.

u/PixelPete85 • 1 points • 2026-02-19 01:12 UTC

Long and short of it is it uses more than if it wasnt there at all